

The Rahul Revolution

Using corporate models, Rahul Gandhi starts a talent hunt for the Youth Congress to spur its revival as a political force and bring in a new generation of leaders

| By Farzand Ahmed |

It's not yet time to shed the kurta pyjama in favour of pinstripes, but down the line, you could well be calling it Congress Inc., if Rahul Gandhi has his way. His current 'talent hunt' to recruit state-level office-bearers for the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) is generating a buzz in the hide-bound parent organisation. Gone is the traditional grassroots-panchayat-assembly ticket route to become state-level office-bearers. Instead, like the present trend in corporate India, the buzzword is walk-in interviews. Candidates armed with their cvs are

grilled by a panel on their vision for the future of the youth wing.

It's clearly a result of Rahul's stint at Harvard and with management guru Michael Porter's consulting firm in London. Politics, after all, is the art of management and the IYC has adopted a corporate culture to identify and prepare a new generation of leaders. By launching his nation-wide talent search, Rahul is bent on re-engineering the IYC into playing a much bigger role in Congress affairs and reconquering Uttar Pradesh through 'Vision 2012'.

The initial signs have been encouraging. Recently, hundreds of young hopefuls with professional degrees

queued up in Lucknow, Allahabad and Jhansi for walk-in interviews for being recruited as Youth Congress leaders. The interviews were corporate style, with V.K. Rathore, IYC general secretary in-charge of Uttar Pradesh, along with two secretaries conducting viva-voce and personality tests. They started with questions like: "How do you propose to build the Youth Congress?" and a quiz on rural development schemes launched by the Centre and how they should be monitored and implemented.

In Lucknow, nearly 200 candidates aged between 17 and 35 appeared for the interviews spread over two days. Among them were 21 engineers, three